

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 4

ART AND ARCHITECTURE OF HARAPPAN PERIOD (PART-2)

SALIENT FEATURES OF THE HARAPPAN CULTURE

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

- 1 The Harappan sculptors were extremely adept at handling three dimensional volumes.



- 2 Chanhudaro in Pakistan was an important center of such crafts which included bead making, metal works, making of seals and artifacts, pottery etc.
- 3 A variety of stones like steatite, quartz and crystals were used. Besides these stones, terracotta and metals like copper, bronze, and even gold were used.
- 4 The above are indicative of high standards of craftsmanship, knowledge of metrology and flourishing trade and commerce.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

SEALS

- 1 Archeologists have found different sizes and shapes of seals all across the excavation sites.



- 2 While most of the seals are square, it was found that the triangular, rectangular and circular seals were also used.
- 3 Steatite a soft stone found in the river belts was the most common material used to make seals.
- 4 The seals have inscriptions in a pictographic script which are written from right to left.
- 5 Animal impressions were also carved on the surfaces of the seals.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

SEALS



6 Generally, the seals had an animal or human figure on one side and an inscription on the opposite side or inscriptions on both the sides.

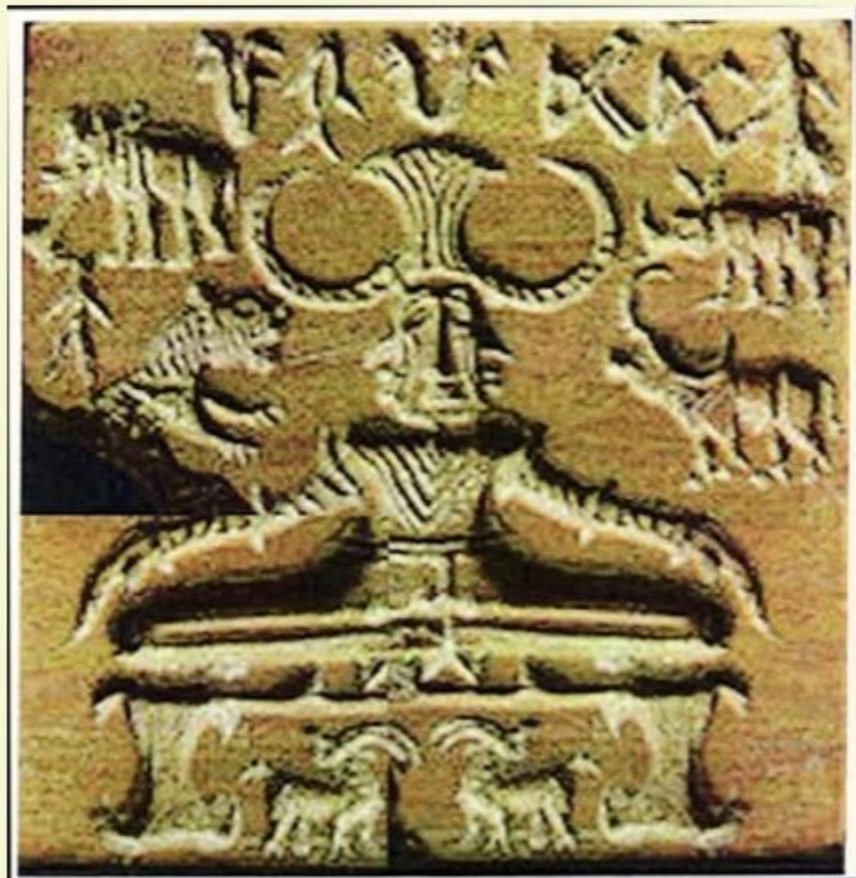
7 Seals were primarily used for commercial purposes, some seals with a hole on them have been found on dead bodies.

8 This indicate that they might have been used as amulets carried on the persons of their owners, probably, used as some form of identification.

9 Mathematical images have also been found on some seals, which might have been used for educational purposes as well

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

SHIVA PASHUPATI SEAL



- 1 The most prominent of the seals found is the Pashupati seal.
- 2 This seal depicts a figure seated cross legged in a yogic posture with a horned head dress.
- 3 The figure is surrounded by number of animals, an elephant & tiger are there on the right side of the figure while a rhinoceros and buffalo are seen on the left side, two antelopes are shown below the seat of the figure.
- 4 The figures considered to be a protoshiva or an early form of shiva/ pashupati/ Rudra, who is venerated as Lord Shiva in Contemporary Hinduism.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

THE UNICORN SEAL

This is another significant seal, which depicts a unicorn, which is a mythical animal (a horse with a single horn)



THE BULL SEAL

This seal shows a humped bull and has good depiction of the features of the animal. A number of seals with animal depictions have been found. All these are indicative of knowledge of wild animals and hunting



SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

THE BRONZE FIGURES



- 1 The Harappan civilizations have the practice of bronze casting.
- 2 The bronze statues were made using “**Lost-Wax Technique**” or **Cire Perdue**. In this technique, a molten metal is poured into a **mould that has been created by means of a wax model**.
- 3 The clay coated figures are then heated allowing the wax to melt. The wax is then poured out through a tiny hole and liquid metal is poured inside the hollow mould.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

THE BRONZE FIGURES

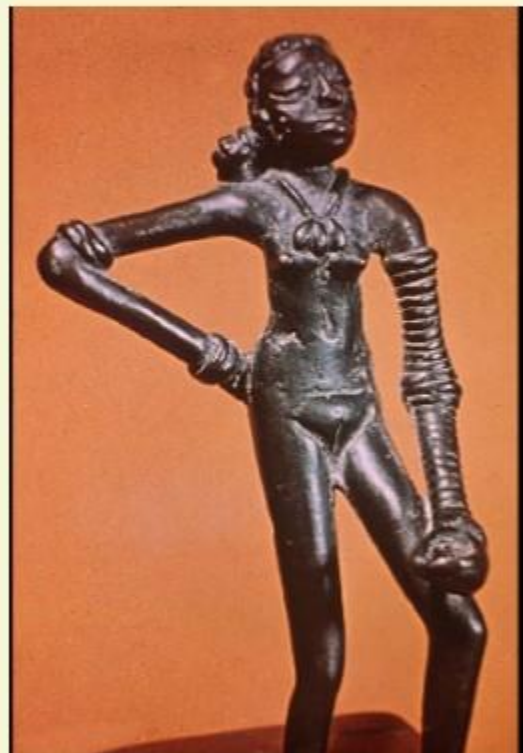


Bronze Bull of Kalibangan

- 4** After the metal has cool down and solidified the clay coat is removed and metal figure of the same shape as the wax figure is obtained.
- 5** Even now the same technique is practiced in many parts of the country.
- 6** Example: Bronze Dancing Girl of Mohenjo-Daro, Bronze Bull of Kalibangan.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

THE BRONZE FIGURES



**Dancing Girl Statue in
tribhanga posture**

THE DANCING GIRL STATUE

- 1** This small bronze statue of a dancing girl found in Mohenjo-Daro is an excellent example of the Art and Metrology of this period
- 2** The statue is dated to around 2,500 B.C. It is the world's oldest bronze sculpture
- 3** This four inch figure depicts a naked girl with only ornaments, which includes the bangles in the left arm and amulet and bracelet on the right arm. She is also wearing a necklace. These arms are shown to be unusually long.
- 4** She stands in "tribhanga" dancing posture with the right hand on her hip.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

TERRACOTTA



- 1 Terracotta refers to the use of fire baked clay for making sculptures. Compared to the bronze figures the terracotta sculptures are less in number and crude in shape and form.
- 2 They were made using pinching method and have been found mostly in the sites of Gujarat and Kalibangan.
- 3 Terracotta was generally used to make toys, animal figures, miniature carts and wheels.
- 4 Example: Mother Goddess, mask of horned deity.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

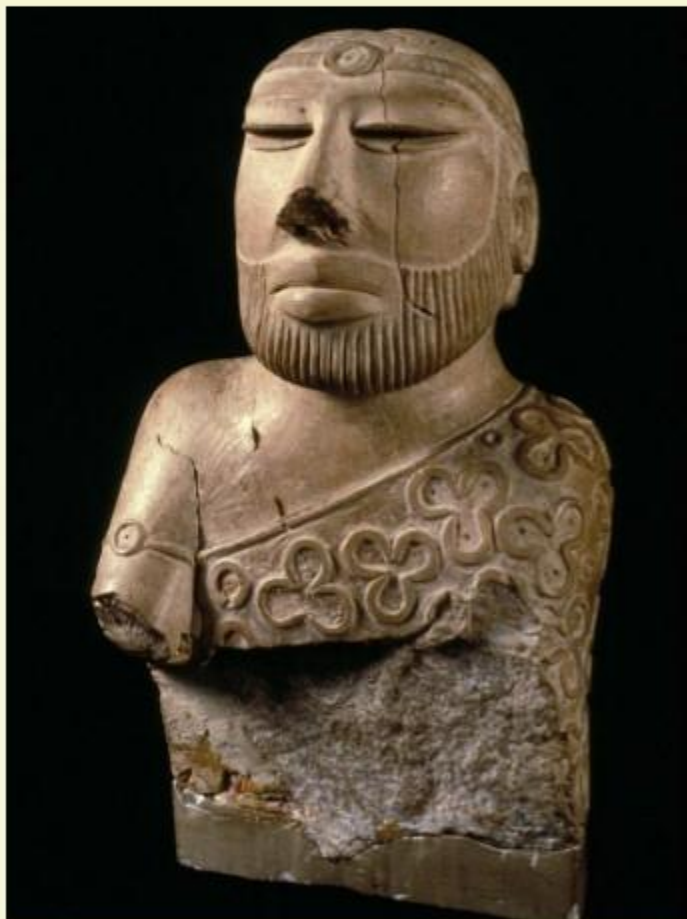
MOTHER GODDESS FIGURE



- 1 This is a terracotta figure of woman adorned with jewellery and imposing fan shaped head gear.
- 2 The mother goddess figures has been found in many Indus sites
- 3 The images of Protoshiva and of the mother goddess indicate religious beliefs of the people of the civilization
- 4 The facial features are shown very crudely and lacks finesse.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

THE BEARDED PRIEST STATUE



- 1 This is one of the best examples of the stone figures found in the Indus Valley Civilization.
- 2 It is the figure of bearded man draped in a shawl with trefoil patterns.
- 3 The eyes of the man are elongated and half closed as in meditation.
- 4 The figure has an amulet on the right hand and a plain woven fillet across the head.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

MALE TORSO



- 1** The red sandstone figure of a Male Torso is another unique specimen of rock sculpture.
- 2** The torso has frontier posture with well baked shoulders and a prominent abdomen.
- 3** There are socket holes in the neck and shoulders probably for the attachment of head and arms.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

PAINTED EARTHEN JAR



- 1** Found in Mohenjodaro, this jar is made on a potter's wheel with clay.
- 2** The shape was manipulated by the pressure of the crafty fingers of the potter.
- 3** After baking the clay model, it was painted with black colour. High polishing was done as a finishing touch.
- 4** The motifs are of vegetals and geometric forms. Designs are simple but with a tendency towards abstraction.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

POTTERY



1 The potteries found at the excavation sites can be broadly classified into two kinds:

- Plain Pottery and
- Painted Pottery

2 Plain pottery is more common than painted ware. Plain pottery is generally of red clay.

3 Trees, birds, animal figures and geometrical patterns were the recurring themes of the paintings.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

POTTERY



Painted Pottery



Plain Pottery

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

POTTERY



4 Most of the potteries that have been found are very fine wheel-made pottery with a very few being handmade.

5 The potteries were used for three main purposes:

- 1) Plain pottery was used for household purposes, mainly storage of grains and water.
- 2) Miniature vessels, generally less than half an inch in size, were used for decorative purposes. They are so marvellously crafted, even now they evoke awe.
- 3) Some of the potteries were perforated- with a large hole in the bottom and small holes across the sides. They might have been used for straining liquor.

SEALS, SCULPTURES AND OTHER ARTIFACTS

ORNAMENTS



- 1 The Harappans used a large variety of materials, from precious metals and gemstones to bones and even baked clay to make ornaments.
- 2 Both men and women wore ornaments like necklaces, fillets, amulets and finger rings.
- 3 Beads made from cornelian, amethyst, quartz, steatite, etc were quite popular and were produced on a large scale, as is evident from the factories discovered in Chanhudaro and Lothal.

UTILITY AND SIGNIFICANCE OF SEALS

- 1 Many seals and similar artifacts pertaining to the Harappan Period have been discovered so far.



- 2 The seals are believed to be used for sealing the consignment of goods and securing them by placing a mark of seal on the opening. Besides the seals were also indication of the identity of the seller.
- 3 The discovery of large number of seals at various sites is an indication of the flourishing trade and commerce and also of the fact that this urban civilization was not agriculture dependent economy.
- 4 The symbols on the seals indicate the existence of a script. The numerous figures throw light on the socio-religious and other aspects of the culture.

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